Chapter Forty

From the Golden Bull to the Baltic Crusade

Between 1218 and 1233,
the king of Hungary is forced to acknowledge
the rights of his nobility,
and the Teutonic Knights
embark on the long conquest of Prussia

RETURNING HOME from his perfunctory visit to the Fifth Crusade, Andrew of Hungary found his country in a state of ferment.

It had been bubbling even before his departure for the Holy Land. Andrew, now in his thirteenth year as king, had started his rule under a shadow. Intended to serve as regent to the actual heir, the five-year-old son of his brother King Emeric, Andrew had instead seized the throne for himself. His sister-in-law had taken the child and fled to Austria, where the conflict was resolved when the boy died of illness the following year.

Three weeks later, Andrew had arranged for the Archbishop of Hungary to crown him as rightful king of Hungary. And, by way of shoring up his claim, he started to give away royal lands to his supporters with abandon. Villages, castle lands, fortresses: anything that fell under his authority as a